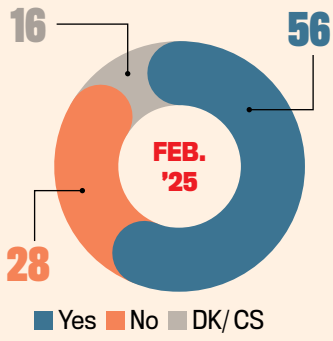
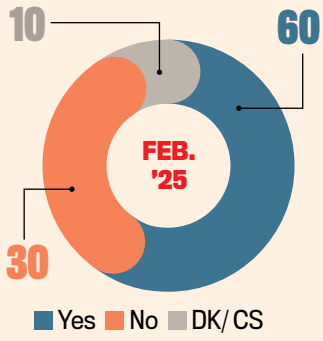
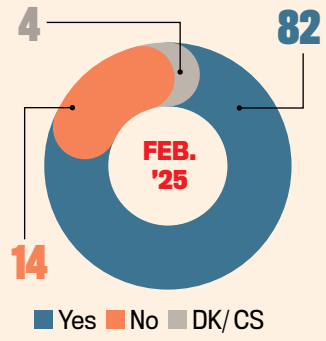
Q. Should government be disinvesting from loss-making PSUs?



Q. Do you think Artificial Intelligence will replace many jobs for the youth?



Q. Should India implement a universal basic income scheme?



Q. Which do you think is the best option for investment?

Stock market	13
Savings with banks	15
Buying land	50
Investing in gold	11
Insurance	5

Rest others; DK/CS

All figures in % and rounded off

HIT BY PRICES, JOB CUTS

The impact of high inflation is telling, with 64.3 per cent of the respondents saying their current expenses have become too difficult to manage, up from 63 per cent in the previous survey. Adding to the strain is the slowdown in wage growth. In urban areas, real wage growth in private companies has dropped from over 10 per cent until Q3FY23 to just 3-4 per cent currently. While there has been some relief on the income tax front, the Centre still needs to rationalise the Goods and Services Tax and reduce the tax burden on various goods to create a more significant impact. Meanwhile, only 6.7 per cent of the respondents say their current expenses have come down.

50%

of respondents from the higher income group say their economic status has improved since the NDA government took charge in 2014

The job situation continues to be precarious. India's unemployment rate rose to nearly 8 per cent in December 2024, the highest since August 2024, according to data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy. It is no surprise, then, that an overwhelming 76.2 per cent of the respondents consider the unemployment situation either very serious or somewhat serious. There is little solace in the fact that this figure is slightly lower than the 78.3 per cent in the previous survey.

After the Modi government assumed office for the third time this summer, the FM in the July 2024 budget announced the PM's package—five schemes and initiatives aimed at facilitating employment, skilling and other opportunities for 41 million youth over a five-year period, with an outlay of Rs 2 lakh crore. However, this has yet to make a significant impact on the ground. Adding to concerns is the fear—justified by many—that Artificial Intelligence will replace a large number of jobs for the youth, the workforce of tomorrow, with 60.2 per cent of the respondents believing it will indeed do so. In light of this, should India implement a universal basic income? An overwhelming 82 per cent think it should.

Meanwhile, the call for the government to exit the 'business of running businesses' remains strong, with 56.3 per cent of the respondents believing it should disinvest from loss-making public sector units. The Centre's disinvestment record has been poor, achieving only 29 per cent of its target between FY21 and FY25. This year, the FM refrained from making any major announcements on disinvestment in the budget, reinforcing the impression that it may be off the table for now.

On the investment front, stability trumps everything else. Given the uncertainty and volatility in the stock market, only 13 per cent choose to put money there; gold and insurance find few takers too, while 15 per cent prefer to keep their money in the bank. The safest option? Land, it seems, as 49.7 per cent vote for it. That is, of those who can. ■